

What Is Existence?

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The question: What is Existence? What exists? Does the thing that exists begin at some time?

This study examines these questions in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta** and selected **modern philosophical and scientific approaches** to physical reality, consciousness, and selfhood.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of nature is hard to avoid: **consciousness appears as something the brain does** — an epiphenomenon, functional outcome, or emergent property of particular configurations of very large numbers of physical particles. Modern physics and cognitive science are powerful on mechanism, prediction, and public evidence; yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain fiercely contested. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of matter-only reductionism.

The work begins where that scientific picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (especially philosophy of mind). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

Quick Glossary

Term	Plain meaning
Existence (<i>astitva</i>)	In Madhyasth Darshan: beingness (<i>hona</i>) and indestructibility (<i>anashita</i>), always present as coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>)	Reality as the pervasive ground (<i>satta</i>) and all units (<i>ikai</i>) inseparably present together.
Time (<i>kaal</i>)	In Madhyasth Darshan: the duration of unit-activity (<i>kriya</i>), not an independent cosmic container; numerical reckoning of duration is a human convention within existence (§1.8). Full treatment: <i>Nature-Of-Time</i> .
Satta (Omnipresence)	The all-pervasive, formless, non-transforming ground in which all units (<i>ikai</i>) are saturated (<i>samprikt</i>). Translation and naming conventions: Editorial Notes.
Saturation-Reflector Model	[Interpretation] Sentience is not generated from dead matter; the ever-present <i>gyan</i> of <i>satta</i> is expressed as active sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) only when a constitutionally complete atom (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>) acts as a stable “reflector.” Canonical exposition: §6.6.
Unit (<i>ikai</i>)	A countable, bounded entity in nature, whether insentient (<i>jada</i>) or sentient (<i>chaitanya</i>).
Jeevan (Sentient Self)	The sentient self: a real, immortal, constitutionally complete unit (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>) that works through the body (<i>shareer</i>).
Constitutional Completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>)	The state achieved when an atom integrates the required number of particles to become indivisible, immortal, and sentient (a <i>jeevan</i>). Crucial to the emergence of sentience in §1.5.
Jada / *Chaitanya*	Insentient and sentient nature (<i>prakriti</i>).
The Four Orders (<i>chaar avastha</i>)	The real, stable developmental plateaus of nature in Madhyasth Darshan: Material (<i>padarth</i>), Pranic/Bio (<i>pran</i>), Animal (<i>jeev</i>), and Knowledge/Human (<i>gyan</i>).
Saturation (<i>samprikt</i>)	The source’s term for how units are held in Omnipresence. Treated in this paper as a metaphor requiring ontological specification (see §1.2).
Atman / *Brahman*	Advaita: the Self and the one ultimate reality, finally identical (§2).
Mithya	Advaita: dependent appearance of the empirical world (§2.3).
Sat-Chit-Ananda	Advaita: being, consciousness, bliss as three names of Brahman (§2.2; contrast §5.3).

Term	Plain meaning
Physicalism	Modern view: every real concrete phenomenon is physical (§3.1).
Panpsychism	Experientiality belongs, at least primitively, to fundamental reality (§3.3).
Strong / weak emergence	Strong emergence: a higher-level property that is not deducible from, and adds something to, its lower-level base. Weak emergence: a higher-level pattern fully fixed by its base. Relevant to §1.5 and §3.3.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence (*astitva*) is the eternally present coexistence (*saha-astitva*) of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless sentient (*chaitanya*) and insentient (*jada*) units (*ikai*) held within it; what exists never arises from non-existence (*abhava*) and is never annihilated, though units undergo motion, transformation, development, and awakening.

Logic in seven steps. The subsections below follow this chain; each heading notes where you are in it.

Step	Question answered	Section
1	What is existence? (coexistence)	§1.1–1.2
2	How do units change?	§1.3
3	What kinds of units exist?	§1.4
4	How does sentience arise?	§1.5
5	What is <i>jeevan</i> ? (knowledge, mereology)	§1.6–1.7
6	Does existence begin?	§1.8
7	How is this unlike Advaita/physicalism?	§1.9

1.1 The Coexistential Structure: Space (*Satta*) and Nature (*Prakriti*)

Madhyasth Darshan does not define existence (*astitva*) as an object among objects, nor as a mental category imposed by a knower. It defines existence as the inseparable presentness of formless *satta* and formful nature (*prakriti*) — not matter arising from consciousness, nor consciousness from matter, but the two inseparably present together as coexistence.

SB gives the most compressed formulation:

“What is evident is that consciousness and matter are inseparably present. Upon examining their fundamental nature, we learn that all of existence is essentially nature (matter) saturated in Omnipotence (consciousness). Here, ‘seeing’ is intended in the sense of understanding. Since nature saturated in Omnipotence is inseparably present, existence itself is eternally manifest in the form of coexistence.” - SB, p. 48

The same passage rejects two familiar origin stories:

1. Matter (*jada*) does not arise from *satta*.
2. *Satta* does not arise from matter (*jada*).

The alternative is not creation of one from the other, but inseparable presentness, expressed in the language of “Realisation Knowledge” (*anubhav jnan*):

“Sentient and insentient nature saturated in Omnipotence. The countless sentient and insentient units are saturated in Omnipotence (Omnipresence).” - MVD, p. 11

“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.” - MVD, p. 11

Existence thus has two inseparable aspects:

1. **Omnipresence (*Satta / Vyapak*):** The formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, immeasurable reality. It is described as actionless energy (*kriya-shunya urja*): it performs no actions, yet its permeative presence is the ground in which nature is energized, regulated, and conserved.

“Omnipotence is not confined within any dimension of length or breadth, nor can any measure be established for it; therefore, Omnipotence is all-pervasive.” - SB, p. 49

“Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space.” - MVD, p. 35

2. **Units of Nature (*Ikai*):** The formful, active, countable, bounded entities. Units are not illusions in Omnipresence; they have determinate reality and remain surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.

“Nature, saturated in Omnipotence, exists as countless units. Each unit, being saturated in Omnipotence, remains surrounded, submerged, and soaked in it.” - SB, p. 48

With these two aspects named, the next question is what “saturation” means ontologically — not merely as an image.

1.2 What Kind of Relation Is “Saturation”? (*Satta* and *Ikai*)

The source describes units as *samprikt* — soaked, submerged, surrounded — in Omnipresence. This is a vivid image, but an image is not yet an ontological relation, and the paper’s central claim (“coexistence”) stands or falls on what this relation actually is. Three candidate readings can be set aside, and a fourth proposed.

Not constitution. Omnipresence is not the stuff units are made of. Units have their own form, properties, and *dharma* (MVD, p. 11); Omnipresence is formless and non-transforming. If units were made of Omnipresence, their transformation would be transformation of it, which the texts deny.

Not inherence (*samavaya*). In the Nyaya-Vaisheshika sense, inherence binds a property to its substance. But Omnipresence is not a property the units possess, nor are units properties of Omnipresence. The relation is mutual and symmetric in a way inherence is not.

Not superimposition (*adhyasa*). This is the decisive contrast with Advaita. For Advaita, the world’s apparent location “in” Brahman is *adhyasa* — a false attribution later sublated. Madhyasth Darshan explicitly refuses this: units are real and perpetual, never sublated. So saturation cannot be *adhyasa*.

Proposed reading: pervasive co-location with mutual energetic dependence. The most defensible reading is that Omnipresence is the omnipresent medium in which every unit is necessarily situated (co-location), and from which every unit draws the regulatory and conserving energy that keeps it in orderly existence — without Omnipresence acting, transforming, or being consumed. SB states this dependence plainly:

“Every unit in its atomic state is active as orderliness, because it has inherent energy due to being saturated in Omnipotence.” - SB, p. 69

“Unit + Energy fullness = Activeness.” - SB, p. 69

The relation is not one-directional. Units depend on *satta* for energy; *satta* depends on units for manifestation as activity. *Satta* remains formless, motionless, and free from pressure, while the whole of nature saturated in it is present with motion and pressure (SB, p. 49). Regulation, activeness, and forcefulness in a unit are seen respectively from its being surrounded, submerged, and soaked in Omnipresence (SB, p. 57). Without unit activity — the source’s term is **basic impulsion** — the energy remains unmanifest; without the energy,

there is no basic impulsion (SB, p. 62). This is mutual dependence for manifestation, not mutual constitution: neither is made from the other, neither is cancelled by the other, and *satta* is never an efficient cause — yet its uniform energy does not appear as energisation, regulation, or activity except through the ceaseless activity of saturated units. **[Open]** Madhyamaka critics (Nagarjuna’s *svabhava* challenge) may ask whether such mutual dependence undermines independent reality; §6.2 develops the reply.

SB presents this dependence not as a single assertion but as a continuous identity-chain, a characteristic Madhyasth Darshan reasoning pattern ($A = B = C = \dots$). The chain in plain terms:

1. Saturation in uniform energy **is** forcefulness.
2. Forcefulness **is** basic impulsion.
3. Basic impulsion **is** activity.
4. Activity **is** effort–motion–result.
5. Effort–motion–result **is** development and its continuity.

Each link is an identity (“itself is”), not an external push. The source states the chain compactly:

“Saturation in uniform energy itself is forcefulness, forcefulness itself is basic impulsion, basic impulsion itself is activity, activity itself is effort-motion-result, effort-motion-result itself is development and its continuity.” - SB, p. 62

So the mutual dependence runs the whole length from saturation to development: *satta*’s uniform energy becomes forcefulness only through the unit, becomes activity only through basic impulsion, becomes development only through effort-motion-result — the same triad named in §1.3 as Effort–Motion–Result (*shram–gati–parinam*).

The “actionless energy” paradox. Omnipresence is called energy and credited with energizing, regulating, and conserving nature, yet is also called actionless (*kriya-shunya*) and non-transforming. The texts resolve this by distributing the terms: *satta* is actionless in itself, but its energy is manifest as the activity of units. “Actionless energy” therefore means latent, uniform energy at the root of activity — present everywhere, never acting on its own, yet inseparable from the activity through which alone it is revealed.

[Interpretation] In standard physics, a physical field is highly dynamical (*kriya-shil*) and active—it carries energy-momentum, exerts force, and propagates waves. Comparing the actionless (*kriya-shunya*) and non-transforming *satta* to a physical field is therefore conceptually misleading. A better physical analogue is a **non-dynamical background geometry** or the **quantum vacuum state** (a uniform, non-acting ground state). The physics analogy of such a background that “permits” motion without moving captures only

the first half (units depend on *satta*); the second half — that energy without unit activity stays unmanifest — is specific to this darshan and must not be dropped.

Consolidated definition of coexistence. On the reading above, coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is: the eternally present inseparability of formless Omnipresence (*satta*) and countless formful units (*ikai*), where every unit is necessarily co-located in the medium, energised and regulated through saturation in it, and where *satta*'s energy is manifest as activity only through those units — ontologically non-identical, neither made from the other, nor projected onto the other, nor finally cancelled by the other.

With coexistence defined, the next question is how change happens within it.

1.3 Causation Within Coexistence

Madhyasth Darshan draws a clear line between **origination** (no unit comes from non-being, §1.1) and **causation** (what produces change when units that already exist transform). These are separate questions; this section answers the second.

Space (*Satta*) is not the efficient cause. Omnipresence grounds and conserves all units through saturation (§1.2), but it does not push, act, or initiate change. MVD presents a four-level causal hierarchy before naming *satta* as *mahakaran* (supreme cause):

Gross (*sthool*) → Subtle (*sukshm*) → Causal (*atma in jeevan*) → Supreme cause (*vyapak / satta*)

1. **Gross (*sthool*):** bodies or objects constituted of many atoms.
2. **Subtle (*sukshm*):** atoms themselves.
3. **Causal (*karan*):** *atma* (within *jeevan*).
4. **Supreme cause (*mahakaran*):** Omnipresence (*vyapak*).

“An object or body constituted of many atoms is referred to as ‘gross’. Atoms are referred to as ‘subtle’. Atma is referred to as ‘causal’. [Omnipresence] is referred to as ‘supreme cause’.” - MVD, p. 288

Satta is the supreme cause in the sense of the sustaining ground — not the trigger of any particular transformation (MVD, p. 289; SB, pp. 49, 62). The causal work of change is done by units themselves.

Insentient units change through Effort–Motion–Result (*Shram–Gati–Parinam*). Physical-chemical activity in the material and pranic orders follows a single irreducible triad:

“Every physical-chemical activity is an inseparable presence of effort, motion and result. Each of these is a joint form of the other two.” - SB, p.

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Effort, motion, and result are not three sequential steps but three inseparable aspects of the same activity, each implying the other two. Because insentient nature is eternally active, every interaction carries this triad. Two structural patterns follow from it:

- **State and motion are inseparable:** there is force in state, power in motion (SB, pp. 248–249).
- **Give–take complementarity:** after reciprocal exchange, both parties return to their natural state — cyclical restoration, not one-way extraction (SB, pp. 52–53).

Change in the insentient orders is therefore always circular and conserved, never one-way or annihilating.

The sentient self (*Jeevan*) changes through Effort–Motion–Resolution (*Shram–Gati–Pratishtha*). *Jeevan*, being constitutionally complete (*gathanpurna*), does not undergo physical-chemical transformation. Its activity does not produce a material result (*parinam*). Instead, *jeevan*’s activity culminates in **resolution or establishment (*pratishtha*)** — the cognitive settling of realization and awakened conduct. The progression is: effort in thought (*shram*) → motion in practice (*gati*) → establishment in realization (*pratishtha*).

In the human order, this cycle is additionally *sanskar*-mediated. Insentient units do not unfold knowledge (*gyan udghatan*); only *jeevan* does, through thoughts (MVD, p. 289; §1.6; [Knowledge, Knower, and Known](#)). In humans the *shram–gati–pratishtha* cycle is shaped by *sanskar* — **acceptances towards completeness, and knowledge, wisdom and science which gets carried forward towards resolution for evidencing** (MVD, p. 90) — and by the reflection–projection cycle, which can lead either toward awakening or toward decline (MVD, pp. 289–291). Awakening, *sanskar*, environment, study, and humaneness form an explicit circular dependency (MVD, p. 290).

Causation within coexistence is now in place; the next step names the kinds of units that undergo it.

1.4 The Ontological Orders and Realist Relations of Nature

Nature (*prakriti*) does not exist as an amorphous mass, but as countless physical (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units.

“Existence is not just physicochemical matter, but all physical, chemical and jeevan entities are inseparably present in Omnipresence.” - MVD, p.

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This is why the human being is understood as a joint form of a physical body (*shareer*) and a sentient self (*jeevan*):

“**Brahma (Omnipotence) is omnipresent, and jeevan-clouds are many.**” - MVD, p. 13

“**The grandeur of humans as a joint form of jeevan and body.**” - MVD, p. 13

Nature is organized into four real, objective **Ontological Orders** (*chaar avastha*), each defined by its innateness and purpose (*dharma*):

1. **Material Order (*Padarth Avastha*):** Bounded physical and chemical units (atoms, molecules, rocks). Its dharma is bare existence (*astitva / hona*).
2. **Pranic / Bio Order (*Pran Avastha*):** Organic cells, plants, vegetation. Its dharma is growth and biological propagation (*pushti / dharana*).
3. **Animal Order (*Jeev Avastha*):** Animals (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of alive-ness (*jeene ki aasha*).
4. **Knowledge / Human Order (*Gyan Avastha*):** Humans (body + *jeevan*). Its dharma is the expectation of continuous happiness and right-living (*sukh-dharmita*).

These are **objective categories in nature**, not human typologies: material atoms, living cells, animal organisms, and knowledge-order humans each occupy a real plateau whose *dharma* is fixed by the order itself. Each order also cyclically manifests through saturation in *satta*, but in a different mode (MVD, p. 289):

Order	Cyclical manifestation through saturation
Material (<i>padarth</i>)	Units are active because of being in Omnipresence
Bio (<i>pran</i>)	Units have pulsation because of being in it
Animal (<i>jeev</i>)	Units have the hope of living because of being in it
Knowledge / Human (<i>gyan</i>)	Units are hopeful and conscientious because of being in it

Cyclicity is real at every order, but not by one identical mechanism — the general circular structures of §1.3 run through all orders; the table names what distinguishes each order.

For readers approaching from neuroscience, Bhattacharya maps how *jeevan* relates to brain and order (material and biological entities without brain; brain-endowed organisms sometimes without *jeevan*; *jeevan*’s activity mediated through the brain in the knowledge order) — **Bhattacharya**, *The Relationship of Jeevan and Brain*; see also [Why-Humans-Are-Not-Just-Material](#).

Why the orders matter for the argument. These orders are not decoration: they are where development without creation from nothing becomes concrete (§1.5). Each order is a real, stable plateau that the next presupposes, so the upward movement from matter to human is development within coexistence, not the appearance of new substance.

SB p. 49 pairs two infinities in characteristic Madhyasth Darshan parallelism: *satta* is immeasurable by pervasion; *prakriti* is countless by count:

“Omnipotence is not confined within any dimension of length or breadth, nor can any measure be established for it; therefore, Omnipotence is all-pervasive. All the units that exist in the form of nature cannot be counted; therefore, they are countless. In this way, existence itself is omnipresent and countless.” - SB, p. 49

The orders also carry the paper’s ethical claim: because existence is coexistence, units exist in objective relations of complementarity (*poorakata*) and orderliness (*vyavastha*). In the source, the conservation principle follows as a **consequence** of coexistence, not as a standalone axiom:

“Since existence is coexistence, complementarity and mutual recognition are eternally established.” - SB, p. 49

Relations (*sambandh*) and values (*mulya*) are therefore ontologically real, perpetual structural aspects of coexistence. In the human order, values like trust (*vishvas*), respect (*samman*), and gratitude (*kritagyata*) are the objective recognition and fulfilment of these existential relations. Unlike physicalism (which tends to treat values as brain-model projections) or Advaita (which treats relations as provisional appearances), Madhyasth Darshan grounds ethical value in the actual structure of existence.

The structure of nature is now in place; the next step is how sentience arises within it.

1.5 Development and Awakening — and the Emergence Problem

While Madhyasth Darshan rejects creation from nothing, it gives a developmental account of how an atom (*parmanu*) reaches sentient status. This is the transition to constitutional completeness (*gathanpurnata*), forming the immortal sentient self (*jeevan*):

“In the course of an atom’s development, there comes a stage when the required number of particles for its constitution are all integrated, and at that point, it becomes constitutionally complete. Constitutional completeness signifies satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution. This is the immortality of the result, and the attainment of sentient status.” - SB, p. 59

“All types of atoms, including constitutionally complete ones, are eternally present through the natural law of coexistence in existence.” - SB, p. 59

SB adds a **quantitative-stability criterion** for constitutional completeness — philosophically significant for the emergence tension:

“In this state of completeness, there is neither an increase nor a decrease in the number of particles in the atom. Due to this stability, the constitutionally complete atom possesses inexhaustible power and force. A constitutionally complete atom undergoes qualitative change without any quantitative change.” - SB, p. 55

The emergence tension (stated, not hidden). This is the most exposed point in the whole system, and honesty requires naming it. The account says a quantitative change — the right number of particles integrating — produces a qualitative change of kind: insentient becomes sentient. That is a strong-emergence claim. Yet in §3.3 the paper leans on Strawson’s argument that experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential. Madhyasth Darshan therefore appears to use against reductive physicalism the very move it relies on for the origin of *jeevan*.

There are three possible replies, and the paper commits to one (see §6.6):

1. **Latency reply.** Sentience does not emerge from nothing; the potential for sentience is “eternally present through the natural law of coexistence” (SB, p. 59). Constitutional completeness is the actualization of a standing potential, not strong emergence.
[Interpretation] This paper adopts this reply, refined through the **Saturation-Reflector Model** (one-sentence preview: the ever-present *gyan* of *satta* is expressed as active sentience only when a stable, constitutionally complete atom acts as a “reflector”; full argument in §6.6).
2. **Threshold-as-form reply.** What changes at completeness is not the addition of a new ingredient but the achievement of a form (a stable self-maintaining constitution). Sentience is identified with that form’s “satisfaction within, by, and for that constitution.” This makes sentience a structural achievement, closer to weak emergence — but then it concedes ground to the self-model theorists of §4.1.
3. **Bite-the-bullet reply.** Accept that this is genuine strong emergence and that the Strawson borrowing in §3.3 must be qualified: Madhyasth Darshan agrees experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, and so must hold that the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential — which pushes back toward the latency reply.

The latency reply is the only one that keeps the system internally consistent with its use of Strawson. What remains **[Open]** is the physical mechanism of reflection, not the interpretive commitment itself (§6.6).

1.6 The “Knowledge but not Knower” Tension

The source calls Omnipresence Knowledge (*gyan*) while denying it the activity of knowing (MVD, p. 35; quoted in §1.1).

A charitable reading: *gyan* here names a condition of intelligibility — reality is such that it can be known, is orderly, transparent, lawful — rather than an act of cognition. On this reading Omnipresence is “Knowledge” the way a perfectly legible text is “meaning” even when no one is reading it. The knowing act (*chaitanya*) still belongs only to *jeevan*.

The texts sharpen this distinction further. MVD p. 289 states explicitly that **the unfolding of knowledge** (*gyan udghatan*) occurs **only** through the sentient aspect (*jeevan*) or thoughts — not through insentient units and not through Omnipresence acting as a knower. MVD p. 115 adds a narrower formulation: knowledge is inherent everywhere, but **its unfolding happens by awakened humans** — a sleeping, deluded *jeevan* cannot unfold it. The same passage describes a sensory/cognitive pathway: vibrational motion on the brain from the cognitive organs leads to the unfolding of knowledge. So *gyan* as a name of *satta* is the intelligibility-ground; *gyan udghatan* is an activity exclusive to awakened *jeevan*. That is why Omnipresence can be called Knowledge without being a knowing subject — and why a careless reading of MVD p. 35 collapses straight into Advaita’s *chit* (Brahman as awareness itself), exactly the identification this paper otherwise resists.

[Open] How the several English names of *satta* cohere as one reality is not fully resolved in the source; see Editorial Notes.

1.7 The Mereology and Identity of *Jeevan*

Two questions the source leaves open, both logically prior to the *jeevan*–body interaction problem.

Is *jeevan* simple or composite? *Jeevan* is called a “constitutionally complete atom” (*gathanpurna parmanu*), which suggests a structured composite (it is complete because the right number of particles integrated). Bhattacharya, synthesizing SB, lists five inseparable aspects — *mun*, *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma* — which supports this reading. But it is also called indivisible and immortal. A composite is, in principle, decomposable; so its claimed indestructibility needs a ground. The most consistent reading is that *jeevan*’s “indivisibility” is functional (the constitution is self-maintaining and does not spontaneously lose completeness) rather than mereological (having no parts). If so, “immortal” means “does not lose constitutional completeness,” which is a weaker and more defensible claim than “has no parts and therefore cannot perish.”

[Open] The Particle Physics Contradiction. From the perspective of modern particle physics, the claim of physical indivisibility for a composite “atom” (*parmanu*) faces severe friction. Modern science shows that all atoms are divisible, and even fundamental particles can be annihilated. Protons are hypothesized in Grand Unified Theories to decay over immense timescales ($>10^{34}$ years). If *jeevan* is composed of physical sub-particles (*ansha*), its physical indivisibility is scientifically implausible. For *jeevan* to be immortal, it

must either: (a) possess binding energy so massive that no cosmic process can disrupt it, or (b) its status as a *parmanu* must operate in a non-physical domain that does not interact via standard gauge bosons—which would then make the mechanism of *jeevan*-body interaction even more mysterious.

What makes this *jeevan* the same *jeevan* over time? Advaita holds that separate individuality was never ultimately real — the appearance of separation is dispelled at liberation (VC, vv. 244, 574); physicalism grounds identity in bodily/psychological continuity. Madhyasth Darshan asserts that *jeevan* persists across bodily death and re-association but offers no explicit criterion of identity. An eternalist individual-self ontology needs one. The candidate implied by the texts is continuity of constitution — the same constitutionally complete configuration persists — but this needs to be stated and defended, because constitution-identity over a gap of embodiment (death to re-association) is exactly where the criterion is hardest.

With *jeevan* characterized, the third paper question — does what exists begin? — can be answered directly.

1.8 Does Existence Begin? Time (*Kaal*) and Conservation

For Madhyasth Darshan, existence does not begin in the sense of coming from absolute non-existence (*abhava*). What exists has always existed, though its form, configuration, and states are in constant flux:

“That which exists continues to be, and that which was not, does not come into existence. Therefore, existence will remain as it is till eternity.” - SB, p. 49

“Nothing arrives at birth nor does anything depart with death. All that is, exists forever.” - JV, p. 20

“Jeevan continues to exist even after death as it does while driving a body.” - JV, p. 20

[Open] The source explicitly infers *jeevan*’s post-death survival from the conservation principle — the most contentious step in the chain from “nothing is annihilated” to “an immortal sentient unit persists.” From the standpoint of modern science, this inference rests on a category error between the **conservation of quantity** and the **conservation of structure (or entity)**. Physics conserves fundamental quantities (mass-energy, spin, electric charge), but does *not* conserve specific structures, configurations, or functional identities. A computer or a biological cell can be destroyed, and while all constituent energy and matter are conserved, the functional identity of the structure is annihilated. Thus, thermodynamic conservation alone does not guarantee the immortality of a structured unit like *jeevan* unless its *gathanpurnata* (absolute physical indivisibility) is already assumed as a separate metaphysical axiom.

The nature of *kaal* (preview)

The third paper question — does what exists begin **at some time**? — presupposes an account of time. Madhyasth Darshan does not treat time (*kaal*) as an independent cosmic dimension, substance, or container in which existence sits. The primary texts define it through **activity**:

“Time (*kaal*): Duration of an activity is referred to as time.” - MVD, p. 34
(also p. 196; p. 338: “Duration of activity”)

Time is therefore inseparable from the motion, change, and effort–motion–result cycles of active units (§1.3). Where there is no transforming activity — in formless, actionless Omnipresence (*satta*) — there is no *kaal* in this sense. *Satta* is non-transforming (*kriya-shunya*); coexistence as a whole is beginningless and endless (below), and SB names one of *satta*’s English equivalents **Eternity** (SB, p. 48).

This is not a denial that units undergo real change. Insentient and sentient units are eternally active; development (*vikas*), cyclical restoration, and awakening are temporal processes **within** coexistence, not passages into or out of existence itself. The circular causality of §1.3 is also a temporal structure: effort, motion, and result are inseparable aspects of ongoing activity, not a static snapshot.

Timeless truth and the three times. SB states that the harmony of consciousness and matter is:

“...a timeless truth valid across all three times.” - SB, p. 48

The Sanskrit *trikaalabadh* (binding across past, present, and future) applies to coexistence as a whole — not to prove that *kaal* is illusory, but that what is understood about coexistence does not come and go with a moment. MVD also describes Omnipresence (*vyapak*) as existing **“at all places and times, and ... eternally present”** (MVD, p. 34). The contrast to keep in view: *satta* is atemporal as ground (formless, non-transforming), yet coexistence is valid across the three times; *kaal* as duration belongs to the activity of units, not to *satta* as efficient cause.

Measurement and numerical reckoning. Duration is real as an aspect of activity, but the **reckoning** of time is conventional within existence:

“Time is measured by the duration of an activity.” - SB, p. 65

“The duration of activity, as time, is a humanly devised numerical reckoning within existence.” - SB, p. 251

“The measurement of time, expanse and different compositions is through mathematics.” - MVD, p. 195

So *kaal* is not a freestanding entity alongside *satta* and *ikai*; it is the duration of unit-activity, made explicit for human purposes through number and mathematics. **[Open]** How past, present, and future relate to “activity eternally present” — a theme developed in JVD (p. 85) — needs a full comparative treatment; see the ongoing study *Nature-Of-Time*.

This ontology distinguishes absolute annihilation (*vinasha*) from physical transformation (*roopantaran*). An entity changes configuration, but its underlying substance (*vastu*) is never destroyed:

“A piece of charcoal continues to exist in other forms even after burning it.” - JV, p. 20

“At the fundamental level, a ‘reality’ never gets annihilated.” - JV, p. 20

The result is a conservation-based ontology:

1. Existence (*astitva*) as coexistence (*saha-astitva*) is beginningless and endless.
2. Omnipresence (*satta*) does not begin, change, or end.
3. Units (*ikai*) do not arise from non-being (*abhava*) and do not vanish into it.
4. Particular bodies (*shareer*), configurations, relations, and states do begin and end.
5. Development (*vikas*) and awakening (*jagriti*) are real, but are not creation out of nothing.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Did existence begin?	No. Existence (<i>astitva</i>) is eternally present coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>).
Did units begin from non-existence?	No. “That which was not, does not come into existence” (<i>abhava</i>).
Do bodies begin and end?	Yes. Birth and death are events at the level of body (<i>shareer</i>) and association.
Does <i>jeevan</i> begin at birth?	No. <i>Jeevan</i> is immortal; birth and death are occurrences.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan answer
Does sentient status have a developmental account?	Yes. Constitutional completeness (<i>gathanpurnata</i>) is attainment of sentient status — within eternal coexistence, not as creation from nothing (see the emergence tension, §1.5).
What is time (<i>kaal</i>)?	Duration of unit-activity; not an independent cosmic container. Numerical reckoning of duration is a human convention within existence (SB, pp. 65, 251; MVD, pp. 34, 195). <i>Satta</i> is timeless as non-transforming ground. Preview only — see <i>Nature-Of-Time</i> .

The Madhyasth answer to all three paper questions is now stated; §1.9 names what distinguishes this ontology from its main rivals.

1.9 The Perpetual World: *Brahma Satya Hai, Jagat Satat Hai*

MVD presents eight co-implicated **Reality** propositions (pp. 12–13). One of them compresses the ontology:

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

The full set gives systematic context — the slogan is not isolated:

1. Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.
2. Brahma (Omnipotence) is omnipresent, and *jeevan*-clouds are many.
3. *Atma, buddhi, chitta, vritti*, and *mun* are indivisible in a *jeevan*-cloud.
4. The grandeur of humans as a joint form of *jeevan* and body.
5. God is omnipresent, deities are many.
6. Human kind is one, vocations are many.
7. Earth is one (undivided nation), States are many.
8. *Jeevan* is immortal; birth and death are occurrences.

Nagraj’s autobiographical account describes the Vedanta formula *Brahma satya, jagat mithya* as part of his intellectual background; Madhyasth Darshan’s *jagat satat* (perpetual world) stands in **structural contrast** with that background within the eight Reality propositions.

Madhyasth Darshan thus rejects two reductions that would split this inseparable whole:

1. **Material reductionism:** only physicochemical matter (*jada*) exists.
2. **World-negating spiritualism:** only the formless ground (*satta*) is finally real, and the world is diminished to mere appearance.

Its positive claim: Brahma is real, the world is real, and their inseparable presentness is coexistence (*saha-astitva*).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

The claim in one sentence: Existence in the strictest sense is Brahman alone, one without a second; the world of names, forms, bodies, and relations is *mithya*, a dependent appearance, and the true Self is neither born nor destroyed because it is identical with Brahman.

Advaita does not deny the empirical world; it subordinates it. The world at *vyavahara* is *mithya* — dependent appearance, not sheer nothing. Advaita's standard framework is **three-tiered**: *pratibhasika* (private apparent error, e.g. rope-snake), *vyavahara* (shared empirical reality — bodies, science, ethics, Ishvara), and *paramartha* (Brahman alone).

2.1 Existence Alone, One Without a Second

“In the beginning this was Existence alone, One only, without a second.”
- CU 6.2.1

Shankara glosses *sat* as:

“mere Existence, a thing that is subtle, without distinction, all pervasive, one, taintless, partless, consciousness” - CU 6.2.1, Shankara commentary

The text rejects existence arising from non-existence:

“By what logic can existence verily come out of non-existence? But surely, o good looking one, in the beginning all this was Existence, One only, without a second.” - CU 6.2.2

2.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda: Being, Consciousness, Bliss

A second classical formulation names existence not only as *sat* — bare being — but as **Sat-Chit-Ananda**: being-consciousness-bliss. These are not three realities added together; Brahman is one partless reality whose nature is expressed in three inseparable names.

“Brahman is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity.” - TU 2.1.1

Shankara's tradition reads *satyam* as being/reality, *jnanam* as consciousness, and *anantam* as the infinite. The *anandamaya* passage (TU 2.5) leads the seeker beyond even bliss-as-sheath to the Self beyond all coverings. Shankara states the mature formula in the *Vivekachudamani*:

“By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy.” - VC, v. 152

The same triad recurs at v. 217, one of the most comprehensive Self-descriptions in the *Vivekachudamani*:

“That which clearly manifests Itself in the states of wakefulness, dream and profound sleep; which is inwardly perceived in the mind in various forms as an unbroken series of egoistic impressions; which witnesses the egoism, the Buddhi, etc., which are of diverse forms and modifications; and which makes Itself felt as the Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute; know thou this Atman, thy own Self, within thy heart.” - VC, v. 217

The Mandukya Upanishad (MU, vv. 3–7) grounds this analysis in the three states (*avastha-traya*): waking, dream, and deep sleep — with **turiya**, the witness beyond all states, as ultimately real. In this scheme:

1. **Sat** — Brahman is existence; to exist absolutely is to be Brahman.
2. **Chit** — consciousness is the very nature of reality and Self, not a function of brain or mind.
3. **Ananda** — bliss is the intrinsic fullness of the Self, free from lack and dependence on objects.

So for Advaita the answer to “what is existence?” is concentrated: existence is the one reality that is being, consciousness, and bliss without a second.

2.3 What Exists in Advaita?

Strict answer: Brahman alone exists absolutely. The world is not sheer nothing, nor absolutely real; it is *mithya*.

“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.” - VC, v. 20

“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.” - VC, v. 216

The clay-pot analogy (a *satkaryavada* illustration; see §5):

“All modifications of clay, such as the jar, which are always accepted by the mind as real, are (in reality) nothing but clay. Similarly, this entire universe which is produced from the real Brahman, is Brahman Itself and nothing but That.” - VC, v. 251

Level	What exists?	Status of world / error
Apparent (<i>pratibhasika</i>)	Rope-snake, dream objects, private errors	Sublated by waking or correction
Empirical (<i>vyavahara</i>)	Bodies, minds, Ishvara, causes, duties, scriptures, science	Shared, law-governed; operationally valid; sublated only by <i>brahma-jnana</i>
Absolute (<i>paramartha</i>)	Brahman alone	World is <i>mithya</i> , dependent appearance

At *vyavahara*, the world is not unreal in the way a hallucination is; it is unreal **relative to Brahman** — like a dream relative to waking. This distinction matters for comparing Advaita’s ethics and science with Madhyasth Darshan’s perpetual world (§6.3).

2.4 The Structural Entities of Advaita

Because Advaita utilizes a three-tier framework of reality, it posits several “entities” that are structurally necessary to explain the empirical world, even if they are ultimately sublated at the absolute level. These are the specific concepts compared against Madhyasth Darshan in §5:

1. **Brahman / Paramatman:** The sole absolute reality (*paramartha*). It is pure, actionless awareness.
2. **Maya:** The cosmic ontological power — Brahman viewed through *Maya* as Ishvara. It conceals Brahman’s true nature (*avarana*) and projects the multiplicity of the world (*vikshepa*). VC vv. 243–244 distinguish **Maya** (cosmic, Ishvara’s superimposition) from **Avidya** (individual, jiva’s superimposition).
3. **Avidya:** Individual ignorance — the jiva’s superimposition of body-mind on the Self. Distinct from cosmic *Maya* (VC, vv. 243–244).
4. **Ishvara (Saguna Brahman):** Brahman associated with *Maya*, functioning as operative cause of name-form manifestation (*vivartavada*) — not a creator *ex nihilo*. Ishvara is a *vyavahara*-level category:

“These two are the superimpositions of Ishwara and the Jiva respectively, and when these are perfectly eliminated, there is neither Ishwara nor Jiva.” - VC, v. 244

1. **Jivatman (Jiva):** The individual embodied soul — the true Self (*Atman*) conditioned by *upadhis* (e.g. *Pancha Kosha*), appearing as separate until realization.
2. **Jagat (Nama-Roopa):** The physical universe of names and forms. Operationally valid at *vyavahara*; ultimately *mithya* at *paramartha*.

First-person method. The *Drig-Drishya-Viveka* (DDV) offers a rigorous seer-seen (*drig-drishya*) discrimination: whatever can be observed — body, sensations, thoughts — is “seen” and therefore not the seer (DDV, vv. 1–5). What remains is *Sakshin*, witness-consciousness — irreducible to matter and closer to Advaita’s first-person route against physicalism than devotional VC passages alone (see §3.2, §6.3).

2.5 Does What Exists Begin?

Brahman does not begin: it is beginningless, partless, actionless, non-dual. The universe as name-form has origination at the empirical level, but its ultimate truth is Brahman. Creation is therefore not production from nothing; it is manifestation of names and forms on the basis of Brahman (*vivartavada* — apparent transformation, contrasted with Madhyasth Darshan’s circular causality in §5.1).

Liberation (*moksha*) is not dissolution or merger of a real individual into Brahman. The jiva was never a separate entity; realization is **recognition of pre-existing identity** with Brahman, in which the illusion of separate individuality is dispelled:

“There is neither death nor birth, neither a bound nor a struggling soul, neither a seeker after Liberation nor a liberated one – this is the ultimate truth.” - VC, v. 574

“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and one’s own Self.” - VC, v. 393

Advaita answers to the three questions:

Question	Advaita Vedanta answer
What is existence?	Brahman alone — being, consciousness, bliss (<i>Sat-Chit-Ananda</i>), one without a second.
What exists?	Absolutely: Brahman alone. Empirically: bodies, minds, Ishvara, duties — all <i>mithya</i> at <i>paramartha</i> .
Does it begin?	Brahman does not begin. Name-form manifests at <i>vyavahara</i> ; liberation is recognition of pre-existing identity.

2.6 Time and temporality

Advaita does not devote a separate chapter to *kaal*, but its framework implies a sharp division. **Brahman** is beginningless, changeless, motionless — outside temporal becoming (VC, v. 393). At *paramartha*, only Brahman is absolutely real; temporality belongs to the empirical order. At *vyavahara*, past, present, and future, birth and death, and causal succession are operationally valid — the world is law-governed and shared (§2.3) — yet finally sublated when Brahman alone is known.

The *Mandukya* analysis of waking, dream, and deep sleep (§2.2) is a first-person route into how temporal **states** appear and are witnessed; the witness (*turiya*) is not another state among them. Madhyasth Darshan accepts the reality of cyclical development and unit-activity across orders (§1.3–1.4) and refuses to sublate the world at the highest realization; its account of *kaal* as duration of activity (§1.8) is therefore closer to a **realist** temporal ontology at every order, while still denying that time is a substance independent of activity. A full comparison with Advaita's *trikaal* language and with Madhyasth Darshan's *trikaalabadh* coexistence claim (SB, p. 48) belongs in *Nature-Of-Time*.

3. Modern Philosophical Approaches

Having examined Advaita Vedanta's world-subordinating non-dualism, we now turn to modern Western philosophy of mind. The contrast is stark: where Advaita asks how the empirical world arises from pure consciousness, modern philosophy asks how consciousness could possibly arise from a purely physical world.

The claim in one sentence: Modern philosophy of mind imposes a consistent pressure—a high burden of proof on any posit beyond the physical—and its debates on consciousness show that “what exists” remains fiercely contested.

3.1 Standard Physicalism: Concrete Reality Is Physical

“I take physicalism to be the view that every real, concrete phenomenon in the universe is...physical.” - Strawson 2006, p. 2

On this view, what exists are physical things, events, fields, organisms, brains, and processes. Minds and selves are functions, organizations, models, or processes of physical systems.

3.2 The Hard Problem: Experience Resists Reduction

“The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience. When we think and perceive, there is a whirl of information-processing, but there is also a subjective aspect.” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

“It is widely agreed that experience arises from a physical basis, but we have no good explanation of why and how it so arises.” - Chalmers 1995, p. 3

“the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism.” - Nagel 1974, p. 1

For Madhyasth Darshan this is evidence that body-only ontology is incomplete. Advaita's DDV offers a complementary first-person route: the seer cannot be the seen (DDV, vv. 1–5), so consciousness resists reduction to observed brain-states — though Advaita and Madhyasth Darshan draw different ontological conclusions from that datum. The physicalist reply — that an explanatory gap is not proof of *jeevan* — is the central disagreement, and the paper should grant that an explanatory gap is, indeed, not by itself an existence proof (see §6.2, §6.4).

3.3 Panpsychist Physicalism: Experience as Fundamental

“Full recognition of the reality of experience, then, is the obligatory starting point for any remotely realistic version of physicalism.” - Strawson 2006, p. 2

“Experiential phenomena cannot be emergent from wholly non-experiential phenomena.” - Strawson 2006, p. 12

“Real physicalism, realistic physicalism, entails panpsychism.” - Strawson 2006, p. 12

This is closer to Madhyasth Darshan than reductive physicalism, since both refuse experience-from-dead-matter. But the agreement cuts both ways. Strawson's anti-emergence principle is exactly what makes the *gathanpurnata* account of §1.5 hard: if experience cannot emerge from the wholly non-experiential, then either the pre-complete atom is not wholly non-experiential (latency reply, §1.5; committed in §6.6), or the threshold account is a form of the emergence Strawson rejects. Madhyasth Darshan also differs from Strawson in scope: it does not say every particle is a subject; sentience is the status of constitutionally complete atoms only. The two views share an enemy (dead-matter reductionism) but not a metaphysic.

3.4 Alternative Ontologies: Process & Neutral Monism

The philosophy-of-mind sources are not the closest Western kin to Madhyasth Darshan; two others are, and this section engages them directly.

Whitehead's process philosophy is arguably the closest analogue: plurality is real, relations are ontologically fundamental, and reality is perpetual becoming rather than static substance. His basic units are "actual entities" — "drops of experience, complex and interdependent" (Whitehead 1929, p. 28) — which resemble units-in-relation, and his refusal to bifurcate nature parallels the refusal of both world-negation and matter-only reductionism. The key contrast: Whitehead's occasions are momentary and "perpetually perish" subjectively, gaining "objective immortality" only as data for successors (Whitehead 1929, p. 44), whereas Madhyasth Darshan's *jeevan* is a persisting immortal individual — so the two agree on relational realism but disagree sharply on individual persistence.

"Actual entities 'perpetually perish' subjectively, but are immortal objectively." - *Whitehead 1929, p. 44*

Neutral monism (Russell, Mach) resembles the account of Omnipresence as a reality that is neither mind nor matter but the common ground of both. Russell holds that mind and matter are "composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material" (Russell 1921, Lecture I). Mach likewise denies any "rift between the psychical and the physical": "There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed" (Mach 1914, Ch. XIV). The contrast: neutral monism typically builds mind and matter out of the neutral stuff, whereas Madhyasth Darshan keeps Omnipresence non-transforming and lets units be real in their own right rather than constructed from the ground.

"Both mind and matter are composed of a neutral-stuff which, in isolation, is neither mental nor material." - *Russell 1921, Lecture I*

"There is no rift between the psychical and the physical, no inside and outside... There is but one kind of elements, out of which this supposed inside and outside are formed." - *Mach 1914, Ch. XIV*

3.5 Illusionism: Phenomenal Consciousness as Misdescription

“Another approach, which holds that phenomenal consciousness is an illusion and aims to explain why it seems to exist.” - Frankish 2016, p. 1

“illusionists deny the existence of phenomenal consciousness properly so-called, but do not deny the existence of a form of consciousness” - Frankish 2016, p. 8

Madhyasth Darshan regards this as another reductionism: it treats experience, valuation, aspiration, and realization as activities of *jeevan*, not brain-model illusions. Illusionism matters because it shows how far naturalism will go to preserve a physicalist ontology.

Modern philosophy answers to the three questions:

Question	Modern philosophy answer (contested)
What is existence?	No unified formula; physicalists name concrete physical reality; panpsychists add primitive experience; process/neutral monism name becoming or neutral ground.
What exists?	Usually the physical; experience, self, and value are disputed (reduced, fundamental, or illusory).
Does it begin?	Particular minds and organisms develop; whether experience or substrate is beginningless varies by school.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

Science does not speak with one voice, but its default ontology aligns with §3.1 physicalism unless the hard problem forces a revision (§3.2–3.3).

The claim in one sentence: Modern science, across cognitive science and cosmology, seeks to explain the self as an emergent natural process and the universe as a physical evolution, occasionally finding resonance with conservation principles but resisting claims of eternal sentence.

4.1 Cognitive Science & Neuroscience: The Brain as Generator of Self

Self-model theories in cognitive science (pioneered philosophically by Metzinger 2003) build upon the physicalist premise. They argue that the self is not an immortal unit, but a predictive model generated by the brain to regulate the organism:

“minimal selfhood emerges as the result” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 1

“these accounts propose to ‘understand the elusive sense of minimal self in terms of having internal models that successfully predict or match the sensory consequences of our own movement, our intentions in action, and our sensory input’.” - Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013, p. 3

This is nearly the opposite of the *jeevan* ontology. For Madhyasth Darshan the self is a real sentient unit using the body; for self-model theory the self is a model generated by embodied prediction. Note, though, the awkward proximity flagged in §1.5: the “threshold-as-form” reading of constitutional completeness moves Madhyasth Darshan uncomfortably close to “self as self-maintaining structure.”

4.2 Physical Cosmology: Does the Physical Universe Begin?

The standard cosmological model suggests the observable universe had a beginning ~13.8 billion years ago. Several non-singular research programs (loop quantum cosmology’s “bounce,” Penrose’s conformal cyclic cosmology, eternal inflation) are comfortable with a beginningless physical substrate even when local configurations begin and end. These are competing speculative programs, not consensus — the most this paper claims is **conceptual resonance** with Madhyasth Darshan’s claim that nature (*prakriti*) is perpetual (*satat*), not proof of it (Ashtekar and Singh 2011; Penrose 2010; Guth 2007).

4.3 Physics & Conservation Laws

The “nothing is annihilated” principle and modern physics — handle with care.

Particle–antiparticle annihilation and pair creation are not passages into or out of absolute non-being: in quantum field theory (see standard treatments, e.g., Weinberg 1995), particles are localized excitations of conserved, all-pervasive fields, and annihilation transforms one excitation (matter) into another (radiation) under strict conservation laws. This is broadly consonant with the claim that fundamental reality (*vastu*) is conserved while configurations (*roop*) transform. But the alignment should not be overstated: fields are not “substances that persist” in quite the sense *vastu* intends, and energy conservation itself is subtle in General Relativity (it is tied, via Noether’s theorem, to time-symmetry that need not hold globally in an expanding spacetime; see Carroll 2010). The right verb is “is consonant with,” not “is supported by.”

Fields vs. *vastu*. In quantum field theory, what persists are field configurations and conserved quantities; a “particle” is a localized excitation, not a tiny enduring substance. Madhyasth Darshan’s *vastu* names an underlying reality that survives every *roop*-change. The parallel is structural (configuration changes, something is conserved), not identity of

category: fields are mathematical-physical entities governed by equations, not countable units with *dharma* saturated in Omnipresence.

Time (*kaal*) vs. spacetime. Modern physics treats spacetime as a dynamical entity — it can expand, curve, and in some models begin locally. Madhyasth Darshan treats *kaal* as the **duration of unit-activity**, numerically reckoned by humans within existence (§1.8; SB, pp. 65, 251; MVD, pp. 34, 195) — not an independent cosmic container. Omnipresence is timeless as non-transforming ground. The contrast is over whether temporality belongs to the ground of reality or only to transforming units, and over whether spacetime is fundamental physics or derivative of measurement conventions on activity. Relational and process philosophies of time (§3.4) share some structural affinity with activity-based *kaal*; block-universe eternalism does not. Comparative detail: [Nature-Of-Time](#).

Entropy vs. orderliness (*vyavastha*). Thermodynamics describes a statistical arrow toward disorder in closed systems. Madhyasth Darshan asserts inherent orderliness at every order, with development toward greater organization when units are in their natural state. These are not straightforward opposites — biological and ecological systems can increase local order at the cost of entropy elsewhere — but they use different notions of “order,” and the paper should not treat the second law as evidence for or against coexistence.

4.4 Summary: Does What Exists Begin, in Modern Thought?

Question	Modern science answer
What is existence?	Physical reality: spacetime, quantum fields, and their excitations — no inherent consciousness or teleology.
What exists?	Matter, energy, organisms, brains, and their processes; the self as brain-generated, not an immortal essence.
Does it begin?	Local systems (organisms, stars, observable universe) begin and end; a beginningless substrate is unsettled; individual consciousness ceases at brain death.

Against all of these, Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger claim: coexistence is eternal, units are not annihilated, and *jeevan* is immortal. This eternalism is consistent with conservation principles and beginningless cosmological models, but its claims about individual immortality and constitutional completeness remain distinct metaphysical assertions not validated by current science.

5. Comparison

This section compares the three traditions systematically; critical evaluation follows in §6.

5.0 Entity categories compared

The matrix in §5.4 is the **primary reference** for cross-tradition comparison. The summaries below prepare its four entity rows; §5.2 gives an at-a-glance summary across traditions.

Modern philosophy (§3):

1. **Cosmic Ground:** Neutral stuff (neutral monism) or creativity/becoming (process philosophy).
2. **Individual Self:** Self-model (physicalism) or experiential monads (panpsychism).
3. **Material Reality:** Physical matter and energy; or the outer aspect of experiential units (panpsychism).
4. **Causation:** Efficient mechanism (physicalism) or creative concrescence (process).

Modern science (§4):

1. **Cosmic Ground:** Dynamic spacetime and quantum fields — no inherent consciousness or teleology.
2. **Individual Self:** Brain-generated cognitive agent; no post-death survival.
3. **Material Reality:** Localized field excitations; conserved under physical law.
4. **Causation & Order:** Physical causation, entropy, evolved ecological cooperation.

5.1 Causal doctrine: *Satkaryavada*, *Vivartavada*, and *Madhyasth Darshan*

Causal doctrine is the deepest structural difference between the three systems — it determines how each answers “does what exists begin?”

Advaita (Sankhya inheritance): *Satkaryavada* — the effect pre-exists in the cause (clay-pot, VC v. 251). At the empirical level, creation is *vivartavada*: apparent transformation of name-form on changeless Brahman — the effect is not a real transformation of the cause. Brahman does not change; multiplicity is projected through *Maya*.

Madhyasth Darshan: Denies single-material-cause reduction and linear efficient-cause chains. *Satta* is *mahakaran* (supreme sustaining cause), not efficient cause (§1.3). Units change through dual activity triads — *shram-gati-parinam* (insentient) and *shram-gati-pratishtha* (sentient) — with circular activity, order-specific cyclicity, and *sanskar*-mediated human cycles. Conservation of *vastu* through *roop*-change resembles *parinamavada* at the unit level, but the full picture is not reducible to “*parinamavada*-like” alone.

Modern physicalism: Strict efficient causation — mechanism, fields, conservation laws. Origination of particular systems is compatible with a beginningless substrate (§4.2); no teleology or supreme ground.

Aspect	Advaita	Madhyasth Darshan	Modern physicalism
Effect in cause?	Yes (<i>satkaryavada</i>)	Units eternal; change is transformation within coexistence	Conservation laws; particles as field excitations
Cause transforms?	No (Brahman changeless; <i>vivarta</i>)	<i>Satta</i> non-transforming; units transform	Fields/spacetime dynamical
Origination vs change	Name-form originates at <i>vyavahara</i> ; Brahman does not begin	No origination from <i>abhava</i> ; development and awakening	Local systems begin/end; substrate unsettled

5.2 At-a-glance comparative summary

Use §5.4 for the full entity matrix; this table compares the three traditions on the paper's main ontological questions and related themes. Causal doctrine in detail: §5.1.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
What is existence?	Eternally present coexistence: Omnipresence plus all units held in it.	Brahman / Existence alone, one without a second.	Concrete physical reality, studied empirically.
What exists?	Omnipresence and real units, sentient and insentient.	Brahman alone (absolutely); world <i>mithya</i> at <i>paramartha</i> .	Usually the physical; experience disputed.
Does it begin?	No — what exists does not come from non-existence; bodies and configurations do.	Brahman does not begin; name-form at <i>vyavahara</i> .	Particular systems begin and end; cosmology unsettled.
Does the individual self begin?	<i>Jeevan</i> does not begin at birth or die with the body.	<i>Jiva</i> is ultimately Brahman; separate individuality dispelled at realization (VC, vv. 244, 574).	Self develops as biological/cognitive process.
What is time?	Duration of unit-activity; human numerical reckoning within existence; <i>satta</i> timeless as ground (§1.8).	Brahman beyond temporal becoming; time valid at <i>vyavahara</i> , sublated at <i>paramartha</i> .	Spacetime as dynamical physical structure; philosophy of time contested.

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern physicalist approaches
Is the world finally real?	Yes. “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”	Empirically valid but ultimately <i>mithya</i> .	Yes, as physical reality.
Method of knowing	Study, realization, behavior, experiment.	Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination.	Observation, modelling, public evidence.
Ethical consequence	Humane conduct evidences understanding of coexistence.	Ethics prepares the mind for liberation.	Ethics via naturalism, social/normative theory.

5.3 The Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast, distributed

Advaita’s Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan’s coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them.

For Advaita, *sat*, *chit*, *ananda* are three names for one ultimate reality without a second; the world is finally *mithya*. For Madhyasth Darshan, the same vocabulary is distributed across coexistence, not compressed into one subject:

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (Unified Non-Dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (Distributed Coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman alone is Sat; the world is a dependent appearance ultimately negated.	Beingness (<i>astitva</i>) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units.
Chit (Consciousness)	Pure awareness, identical to the inner Self; the world of names/forms is inert.	Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge/condition-of-intelligibility (§1.6), but active sentience (<i>chaitanya</i>) belongs to the <i>jeevan</i> unit.
Ananda (Bliss)	Intrinsic nature of Brahman; sensory joy is a distorted reflection.	Harmony realized within the awakened <i>jeevan</i> , expressed as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

5.4 Comparative Matrix of Entities

Primary reference. The table below is the compact cross-tradition map; §5.2 summarizes key questions side by side; §5.5–5.6 walk the Advaita mapping in narrative form.

The table compares primary entities across the four traditions this paper develops in the body. Abrahamic, Buddhist, and Dvaita ontologies are outside scope; they are not included here.

Entity Category / Attribute	Madhyasth Darshan (Co-existentialism)	Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)	Contemporary Philosophy (Process, Physicalist, Panpsychist)	Modern Science (Physics, CogSci, Cosmology)
Cosmic Ground	Omnipresence (<i>Satta / Space</i>): Pervasive, formless, actionless energy (<i>kriya-shunya</i>). Units depend on it for energy; its energy manifests as activity only through units (§1.2).	Brahman: The single, non-dual absolute reality (<i>Sat-Chit-Ananda</i>). The world is <i>mithya</i> (dependent appearance) at <i>paramartha</i> .	Creativity / God (Process): Dynamic process. Neutral Stuff (Neutral Monism): Common element.	Spacetime & Quantum Fields: Dynamic, physical substrate. No inherent consciousness or teleology.
Individual Self / Sentience	Jeevan: A constitutionally complete, immortal atom (<i>gathanpurna parmanu</i>). Many distinct, eternal <i>jeevan</i> exist.	Jivatman / Atman: Individuality (<i>jivatman</i>) is a <i>vyavahara</i> superimposition (VC, v. 244). The true Self (<i>Atman</i>) is identical to Brahman.	Self-Model (Physicalist): Evolved cognitive model. Experiential Monads (Panpsychism): Fundamental experience.	Cognitive Agent / Organism: Brain-generated process. Mind is what the brain <i>does</i> . No survival post-death.

Entity Category / Attribute	Madhyasth Darshan (Co-existentialism)	Advaita Vedanta (Non-Dualism)	Contemporary Philosophy (Process, Physicalist, Panpsychist)	Modern Science (Physics, CogSci, Cosmology)
Material Reality / Body	Jada Units / Shareer: Real, perpetual, transforming matter. Composes the body, which acts as the vehicle for <i>jeevan</i> .	Nama-Roopaa / Mithya: Form and name; robust at <i>vyavahara</i> ; sublated at <i>paramartha</i> .	Physical Matter: The primary concrete reality (Physicalism); or the outer aspect of experiential units (Panpsychism).	Matter & Energy: Consolidated excitations of quantum fields. Governed by conservation laws. Perpetual in base fields.
Relationships & Moral Order	Coexistence / Complementarity: Inherent, ontologically real values (<i>mulya</i>) and orderliness (<i>vyavastha</i>).	Ethics at <i>vyavahara</i>: Valid to purify the mind; <i>loka-sangraha</i> (BG); sublated at <i>paramartha</i> .	Social / Internal Relations: Relationality constitutes the self (Process); or evolutionary strategies for survival (Physicalism).	Ecology & Cooperation: Interdependent biological networks. Cooperation is an evolved behavioral strategy.
Primary Causation	Circular mutual causality (§§1.2–1.4): <i>Satta</i> as <i>mahakaran</i> ; dual activity triads; circular activity; <i>sanskar</i> -mediated human cycles.	Vivartavada: Apparent transformation on changeless Brahman (<i>satkaryavada</i> background).	Efficient / Creative Causation: Physical mechanisms (Physicalism); or “concrecence” (Process).	Physical Causation: Mathematical laws, conservation, entropy.
Ultimate Purpose / Realization	Awakening (<i>Jagriti</i>): Realization of coexistence, leading to resolved humane conduct (<i>manaviya aacharan</i>) in society.	Liberation (<i>Moksha</i>): Recognition of identity with Brahman; illusion of separate self dispelled (VC, v. 574).	Flourishing / Adaptation: Cognitive adaptability (Physicalism); aesthetic intensity of experience (Process).	Survival & Adaptation: Natural selection, entropy minimization (Friston 2010), homeostasis.

5.5 Is It Possible to Map Madhyasth Darshan to Advaita?

For a compact entity comparison, see §5.4; this section walks the mapping argument in detail.

While the two systems arise from different core commitments (Advaita: non-dualism; Madhyasth Darshan: co-existentialism), several key entities in Advaita find close analogues or functional equivalents in Madhyasth Darshan:

1. Brahman corresponds to *Satta* (Omnipresence / Space)

- **Mapping:** Both are formless, all-pervasive, non-transforming, timeless, and actionless. Both serve as the ontological ground of everything.
- **Divergence:** Advaita's Brahman is the *sole* absolute reality (*paramartha*), making the world an appearance (*mithya*). Madhyasth Darshan's *Satta* coexists with nature (*prakriti*); both are real. Brahman is awareness itself (*chit*), whereas *Satta* is actionless energy (*kriya-shunya urja*)—the condition of intelligibility—while active sentience (*chaitanya*) belongs exclusively to the *jeevan* unit (§1.6).

2. Paramatman / Atman corresponds to *Atma* (in *Jeevan*) / *Jeevan*

- **Mapping:** Both point to the true, immortal, non-material reality of the self. Within the five-fold structure of *jeevan*, the *Atma* represents the innermost core of realization.
- **Divergence:** Advaita holds that the true Self (*Atman*) is exactly identical to the single, universal Supreme Self (*Paramatman*). Madhyasth Darshan denies a single universal self; it holds that *jeevan* units are permanently distinct, multiple, and active.

3. Jivatman (Jiva) corresponds to Deluded *Jeevan* (*Bhramit Jeevan*)

- **Mapping:** Both represent the individual embodied self experiencing the world, bound by ignorance (body-identification), and seeking liberation or resolution.
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, the *jivatman*–*Paramatman* duality is maintained only at *vyavahara* due to conditioning (*upadhis*); upon liberation, the duality is seen to have been false — what remains is Brahman alone (VC, v. 244). For Madhyasth Darshan, individuality is ontologically real and eternal; realization (*jagriti*) resolves delusion but preserves the active, distinct individuality of the *jeevan*.

4. Jagat / Nama-Roopa corresponds to Nature / Units (*Prakriti* / *Ikai*)

- **Mapping:** Both point to the physical universe of change, bodies, name, and form.
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, the Jagat is ultimately *mithya* (dependent appearance) and sublated at the highest realization. In Madhyasth Darshan, the world of units is *satat* (perpetual) and eternally real.

5. Pancha Kosha (Five Sheaths) corresponds to Five Functional Layers

- **Mapping:** Both map human structure through five layers: *annamaya* (food/body), *pranamaya* (vitality), *manomaya* (mind), *vijnanamaya* (wisdom/intellect), and *anandamaya* (bliss/realization).
- **Divergence:** In Advaita, the sheaths are eliminated through reasoning on Shruti passages (VC, vv. 210, 639), revealing the Self beneath — not primarily through *neti-neti* (which belongs to the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad). In Madhyasth Darshan, they are the **real functional equipment** of the human being (comprising body and *jeevan*) that are affirmed and harmonized in awakened living.

5.6 Unmappable Entities

Certain central entities and categories in Advaita Vedanta cannot be mapped to Madhyasth Darshan because they represent concepts that co-existentialism explicitly rejects:

1. Maya (as an Ontological Power of Projection/Concealment)

- Advaita's *Maya* is the cosmic power that conceals Brahman (*avarana*) and projects the illusion of the world (*vikshepa*). Madhyasth Darshan has no equivalent cosmic power or substance of illusion. Ignorance (*agnyan / bhrama*) is not a force or substance but merely the temporary cognitive absence of understanding (lack of awakening), which is resolved through study and education.

2. Adhyasa (Superimposition)

- In Advaita, the world is superimposed (*adhyasa*) on Brahman like a snake on a rope. Madhyasth Darshan has no concept of ontological superimposition. The relationship between units and *Satta* is **saturation (*samprikt*)**—a real, mutual, non-reductive co-location: units depend on *satta* for energy; *satta* depends on units for manifestation as activity (§1.2; SB, pp. 57, 62, 69)—not a projection or false attribution.

3. Mithya (Ontological Status of Dependent Appearance)

- Advaita introduces *mithya* (strictly *sad-asad-anirvacaniya* — neither absolutely real nor sheer nothing) to describe the world. Madhyasth Darshan rejects any intermediate ontological status: everything that exists is real, perpetual, and indestructible.

4. Ishvara (Saguna Brahman / Governor)

- In Advaita, Ishvara is Brahman associated with *Maya* — operative cause of name-form manifestation, a *vyavahara*-level category sublated at *paramartha* (VC, v. 244), not a personal creator *ex nihilo*. Madhyasth Darshan rejects a personal creator deity who plans, acts, or dispenses grace. Orderliness (*vyavastha*) is self-regulation (*swatah-saspurt*) inherent in the natural laws of the co-existing orders, and *Satta* is entirely actionless (*kriya-shunya*).

5. Kaivalya / Recognition of identity (as Ultimate Liberation)

- Advaita seeks **recognition of pre-existing identity with Brahman**, in which the illusion of separate individuality is dispelled (*jiva-brahma-aikya* — unity/identity, not merger; VC, vv. 244, 574). Madhyasth Darshan holds that individual *jeevan* units remain eternally distinct; the ultimate goal is **awakened coexistence (*jagriti*)**, where *jeevan* units remain active in harmonious relationships (*sambandh*) with other humans and the ecological orders.

Conclusion on Mapping: The attempt to map Madhyasth Darshan to Advaita Vedanta reveals fundamental difficulties. While surface-level analogues exist, the core ontological commitments are ultimately irreconcilable. Advaita is a world-subordinating non-dualism that views individuality and the universe as dependent appearances (*mithya*) to be transcended. In stark contrast, Madhyasth Darshan is a relational realism that affirms the eternal distinctness of sentient units and the perpetual reality of the world. Because of these profound differences, a true one-to-one mapping is impossible without distorting the foundational claims of either system.

5.7 Where the alliances fall

No single tradition wins every dispute. Three pairwise patterns clarify what each view shares with and denies to the others:

Madhyasth Darshan and Advaita against physicalism. Both refuse to treat existence as merely physicochemical matter. Consciousness, value, and the self are not exhaustively explained as brain-generated epiphenomena. Against reductive materialism, both hold that something more than bare mechanism is required — though they disagree sharply on what that “more” is.

Madhyasth Darshan and science against Advaita. Both treat the world as real and worth studying. Matter, bodies, relationships, and ecological order are not finally *mithya* or preparatory illusion. Against world-negating non-dualism, both insist that nature and society have final weight — though science does not affirm Omnipresence or immortal *jeevan*.

Advaita and science against Madhyasth Darshan. Both set a high bar for claims that exceed public evidence. Advaita holds that separate individuality was never ultimately real (VC, v. 574); science treats the self as a biological process that ceases at brain death. Against Madhyasth Darshan’s eternal distinct sentient units, both deny — on different grounds — that an immortal individual self is established.

Each pair agrees on something the third denies. Comparative clarity depends on naming which question is at stake: matter-only reduction, world-reality, or individual immortality.

6. Critical Review

6.1 Internal coherence of the Madhyasth Darshan position

Judged on its own definitions — not as proof against rivals — the ontology hangs together in several ways:

1. **It answers the three questions directly.** Existence is beingness and indestructibility as coexistence; what exists is Omnipresence and all units; what exists does not begin from non-being.
2. **It avoids world-negation.** “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual” preserves the reality of nature, society, relationship, and ethical responsibility.
3. **It avoids simple material reductionism.** It refuses to treat consciousness, value, and selfhood as mere byproducts of body-chemistry.
4. **It links ontology and conduct.** If existence is coexistence, human fulfilment must be evidenced as coexistence in behavior, not merely believed.
5. **It is conservation-based.** “Nothing existent is annihilated” gives internal coherence to its account of body, *jeevan*, death, transformation, and development.

These are strengths **within** the system’s premises. They do not by themselves establish those premises against Advaita or physicalism (see §6.2–§6.6).

6.2 Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan — argued

The items below mark what any later rigorous treatment must settle. Each is stated with why it matters, not merely listed. **[Interpretation]** committed in §6.6 is distinguished from **[Open]** mechanism and evidence gaps.

Internal coherence

1. **The emergence of sentience (§1.5).** Constitutional completeness appears to require a quantitative threshold producing a qualitative change — strong emergence. Yet the paper borrows Strawson’s anti-emergence principle against physicalism. The latency reply is **[Interpretation]** committed in §6.6; **[Open]** the physical mechanism of the Saturation-Reflector Model remains unspecified.
2. **Mutual dependence and the Nagarjuna challenge (§1.2).** The paper states that units depend on *satta* for energy and *satta* depends on units for manifestation as activity. Nagarjuna’s critique of *svabhava* (intrinsic existence) asks whether such mutual dependence makes neither independently real — precisely the challenge Madhyasth Darshan must answer if coexistence is not to collapse into dependent co-arising without enduring units. The texts’ answer, implicit in the eternity of both *satta* and *ikai*, is that coexistence is beginningless: neither pole is ontologically posterior to the other. That reply needs explicit defense against Madhyamaka-style reduction.
3. **Satta–Ikai relation and circular causality.** §1.2–1.3 state mutual dependence and dual activity triads in prose; what remains is formalization — not discovery of whether the texts assert them.

5. Mereology and identity of jeevan (§1.7). Functional vs. mereological indivisibility, and identity across the death-to-re-association gap, need explicit criteria. JV p. 20 infers post-death survival from conservation. **[Open]** This inference commits a category error by conflating quantity conservation (standard thermodynamics) with structural/entity conservation. Furthermore, the claim of physical indivisibility of *jeevan* as a *parmanu* directly contradicts modern particle physics, where no physical bound state of particles is absolutely indivisible or immune to decay/annihilation.

7. Jeevan–body interaction. If *jeevan* drives the body, the mechanism from intention to neural and muscular activity is unspecified.

Evidence and science

6. Constitutional completeness is not operational. Central to the ontology but not presently measurable in physics or chemistry.

8. Evidence standard vs. science. Realization and behavior are cited; science requires public testability. What would count as evidence for *jeevan* beyond the hard-problem explanatory gap? §6.4 addresses this.

Comparative (deferred)

4. “Knowledge but not knower” (§1.6). Comparative work must not collapse Omnipresence-as-*gyan* into Advaita’s *chit*. Naming tensions in the English translation: Editorial Notes. The full epistemic account belongs in [Knowledge, Knower, and Known](#).

9. The nature of time (§1.8). This paper states Madhyasth Darshan’s core claim — *kaal* as duration of activity, not independent substance; timeless *satta*; numerical reckoning within existence — but does not yet treat past/present/future structure, the relation of “activity eternally present” to human temporal experience (JVD, p. 85), or systematic comparison with Advaita *trikaal* language, McTaggart, eternalism/presentism, and spacetime physics. That work is reserved for [Nature-Of-Time](#).

6.3 Strengths and Limits of Advaita

Advaita has a powerful answer to non-being (existence cannot arise from non-existence, CU 6.2.2) and a rigorous first-person method — DDV’s seer-seen discrimination and MU’s three-state analysis (§2.2, §2.4). Its limit, from the Madhyasth perspective, is that making the world *mithya* at *paramartha* makes it harder to ground the **final** ontological weight of relationships, nature, society, and conduct — even though *vyavahara* is robust, shared, and law-governed (§2.3).

Advaita’s fair reply is substantial and should not be dismissed in a sentence. At *vyavahara*, ethics and compassion remain fully valid; realization of non-duality deepens rather than weakens them. Shankara’s *Vivekachudamani* insists on ethical discipline as prerequisite to knowledge (VC, vv. 17–19). The Bhagavad Gita, in Shankara’s commentary, grounds social responsibility in *loka-sangraha* — holding the world together — and ordained duty (*niyatam kuru karma*, BG 3.8): the enlightened still act for the welfare of the world. Advaita can

therefore reply to the charge that *mithya* makes ethics untenable: ethics is binding at the level where life is actually lived.

The Madhyasth counter-reply is narrower but precise: an ontology that makes the world *mithya* at *paramartha* cannot give the world the **same final weight** coexistence gives it — relationships and nature are ultimately sublated, not perpetual. This is a genuine disagreement about final ontological status, not a defeat of Advaita on its own terms. The three-tier framework (§2.3) shows Advaita's *mithya* is not sheer unreality like a hallucination (*pratibhasika*); the dispute is over whether *vyavahara*'s robustness suffices for Madhyasth Darshan's standard of final world-realness.

6.4 Strengths and Limits of Modern Approaches

Modern approaches are strongest where Madhyasth Darshan is weakest: public evidence, empirical correction, cognitive modelling, precise mechanism. Self-model theory explains many features of embodied selfhood without an eternal *jeevan*; illusionism shows how a naturalist can reinterpret even the apparent obviousness of experience.

But modern philosophy is not unified. Chalmers and Nagel show experience resists reduction; Strawson shows some physicalists move toward panpsychism. It is inaccurate to say “modern philosophy has proved the self is only the brain.” What modern philosophy **has** established is a high evidential bar: an explanatory gap is not an existence proof for *jeevan*.

What would count as evidence? Public science would require at minimum: (a) operational criteria for constitutional completeness independent of the philosophy; (b) reproducible markers distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity; (c) independent evidence for post-death continuity of a sentient unit. Until then, Madhyasth Darshan's claims about immortal *jeevan* remain metaphysical assertions compatible with conservation principles but not validated by current science — while the hard problem shows physicalism's own exposed point (§3.2).

6.5 Epistemology: partially incommensurable criteria

The three systems do not merely give different answers; they use different criteria for what counts as knowing:

Tradition	Method	Adequate for
Madhyasth Darshan	Study, realization, behavior, experiment	Coexistence as lived evidence; conduct as proof of understanding
Advaita	Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination (DDV, VC)	Self as Brahman; sublation of <i>mithya</i>
Physicalism	Observation, modelling, public evidence	Mechanism, prediction, third-person confirmation

To that extent they are **partially incommensurable** — no single neutral tribunal settles them. What this paper attempts is narrower: test each for internal consistency, fit with public knowledge, and responsible distinction of posits from bare assertion. The epistemic standards of realization as proof are examined in [Knowledge, Knower, and Known](#).

6.6 Committed interpretation: latency and the Saturation-Reflector Model

If Madhyasth Darshan is to borrow Strawson's anti-emergence principle against physicalism, it owes an explicit reply to the emergence tension (§1.5). This paper commits to the **latency reply** as the only internally consistent option, refined through the **Saturation-Reflector Model** (previewed in §1.5; canonical exposition here):

1. **Textual basis.** SB p. 59: all atom types, including constitutionally complete ones, are “eternally present through the natural law of coexistence.” Sentience is not created at completeness; it is actualized.
2. **Quantitative-stability support.** SB p. 55: at completeness, particle count is fixed; change is qualitative without quantitative addition — not the arrival of a new experiential ingredient from non-experience.
3. **Where potential resides.** Rather than locating latency in an abstract “law of coexistence,” the Saturation-Reflector Model holds that the potential for sentience is eternally present in the all-pervasive ground of *satta* (which is defined as *gyan*, the ground of all knowledge/consciousness). Insentient (*gathan-shil*) atoms lack the stable configuration required to express/reflect this ground. Once an atom achieves constitutional completeness (*gathanpurnata*), its stable configuration acts as a “reflector,” allowing the ever-present *gyan* of *satta* to manifest as active sentience (*chaitanya*). This resolves the Strawson anti-emergence challenge by showing that experience is never generated from dead matter, but is mediated by structured matter from an ever-present conscious ground.
4. **What remains open.** This model is still a metaphysical framework, not a detailed physical mechanism. It keeps the system consistent with Strawson but does not answer physicalism's demand for third-person public evidence (§6.4), nor does it reconcile the physical indivisibility of the *parmanu* with modern particle physics.

[Open] Formalizing “latency within the law of coexistence” — and defending it against Nagarjuna's *svabhava* critique (§6.2) — is the most promising route for later rigorous work.

7. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's answer to the paper's three questions is exact:

1. **What is Existence?** Eternally present coexistence: formless Omnipresence and formful units inseparably present.

2. **What exists?** Omnipresence exists; countless sentient and insentient units exist; their form, properties, nature, dharma, mutuality, and orderliness exist.
3. **Does what exists begin?** No. What exists does not come from non-existence and is not annihilated. Bodies and configurations begin and end; existence and existent realities persist through transformation.

Its most distinctive formulation —

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” - MVD, p. 13

— marks the difference from Advaita and physicalism at once: against Advaita, the world is not *mithya*; against physicalism, existence is not merely physicochemical matter; against both, reality is neither world-negation nor matter-only, but coexistence.

The philosophical strength of this view is that it makes the world, relationships, conduct, and ecological responsibility fully real. Its unresolved challenges are two, and they are different in kind:

- **Evidential challenge** (§6.2, items 6 and 8; §6.4): clarifying how *jeevan*, constitutional completeness, and post-death continuity can be studied or responsibly distinguished from metaphysical assertion.
- **Internal-coherence challenge** (§6.2, items 1–3, 5, 7; §6.6): formalizing saturation and circular causality beyond the prose account of §§1.2–1.3, and specifying the physical mechanism of the Saturation-Reflector Model.

Comparative clarity is achieved when the reader can state, for each of the three questions, where Madhyasth Darshan, Advaita, and physicalism agree — and where §5.7’s three pairwise alliances divide them: MD and Advaita against physicalism on matter-only reduction; MD and science against Advaita on final world-reality; Advaita and science against MD on individual immortality.

In Madhyasth Darshan itself, careful study of existence is only the starting point. Understanding is fulfilled when coexistence becomes clear in one’s own seeing and evident in conduct — in recognition of relationships, fulfilment of values, resolution in thought, responsible work and experiment, and the ability to convey the understanding to others. The open problems listed in §6.2 are therefore not reasons to dismiss the comparative project; they mark where study, responsible experiment, and later rigorous work must continue.

Editorial Notes

Translation and editorial conventions (*satta*)

The source texts’ primary English term for the all-pervasive, formless reality (*satta*) is **Omnipotence**; *vyapak* (“all-pervasive”) is rendered “Omnipresence” in the English

translation. The English translation alternates **Omnipotence** and **Omnipresence** for the same *satta*; Hindi *satta* is the constant behind both. To avoid the theistic connotations of “Omnipotence,” this paper uses “**Omnipresence**” as its running English term in analytical prose. Block quotes preserve whichever word the translation prints. Where Hindi *shunya* appears, the translation renders it **Space** — void/emptiness (actionless, formless), not physical *akasha*.

“Consciousness” in SB p. 48

The English translation lists several names for the pervasive reality (*Satta / Vyapak*): Uniform Energy, Space (*akasha*), Knowledge (*gyan*), Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy. In SB p. 48, the parenthetical “(consciousness)” labels the all-pervasive reality, not a personal knowing mind. Sentience as the activity of a knower (*chaitanya*) is the status of *jeevan* (the sentient unit), not of Omnipresence (*satta*) itself. This distinction is essential, and it also generates a genuine tension in the source, addressed in §1.6.

Naming tensions for *satta*

The source gives *satta* multiple English names. Several generate internal tensions if treated as interchangeable:

Name	Tension
Knowledge / Consciousness	Implies cognition — yet <i>satta</i> is denied as knower (§1.6).
Space / <i>Shunya</i>	Void/emptiness vs. fullness of energy; <i>shunya</i> is rendered “Space” in the English translation, not physical <i>akasha</i> .
God	Personhood vs. actionless, non-willing <i>satta</i> .
Absolute Energy	Dynamism vs. <i>kriya-shunya</i> (actionless).
Uniform Energy, Eternity	Listed alongside the names above; no single English label captures all aspects.

[Open] How these names cohere as one reality is not fully resolved in the source.

Advaita: *mithya* and *sad-asad-anirvacaniya*

The *mithya* doctrine and Advaita’s three-tier framework (*pratibhasika*, *vyavahara*, *paramartha*) are related but distinct tools; §2 keeps them apart. The compound *sad-asad-anirvacaniya* is a post-Shankara systematic term (Vimuktatman, Vivarana school); Shankara uses “neither sat nor asat” language without that compound.

References

All sources cited in this document, grouped by tradition. Each entry begins with the bold tag used in the text. Local copies live under [References/](#) where noted; external works link to the original publisher or author page (see [NOT-DOWNLOADED.md](#)).

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. *Madhyasth Darshan — Co-existentialism*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: Realisation Knowledge (p. 11); Omnipresence/Space (pp. 11, 13, 35); eight Reality propositions (pp. 12–13); “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual” (p. 13); gist of coexistence (p. 5); *vyapak* at all places and times (p. 34); time (*kaal*) as duration of activity (pp. 34, 196, 338); measurement of time through mathematics (p. 195); knowledge unfolding by awakened humans (p. 115); *sanskar* definition (p. 90); four-level causal hierarchy (p. 288); order-specific cyclical manifestation and knowledge unfolding through *jeevan*/thoughts (p. 289); reflection–projection cycle (pp. 290–291).
- **SB** — Nagraj, A. *Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad (Resolution Centred Materialism)*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: existence as nature saturated in Omnipotence (p. 48); timeless truth across three times (p. 48); Omnipotence all-pervasive and countless units (p. 49); complementarity from coexistence (p. 49); give–take reciprocity (pp. 52–53); regulation, activeness, forcefulness from saturation in Omnipotence (p. 57); effort–motion–result triad (p. 58); constitutional completeness and quantitative stability (pp. 55, 59); identity-chain and basic impulsion (p. 62); unit energy from saturation (p. 69); time measured by duration of activity (p. 65); humanly devised numerical reckoning of time (p. 251); state–motion inseparability (pp. 248–249).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. *Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: birth, death, conservation, and *jeevan* post-death continuity (p. 20).

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Verse and section numbers follow standard numbering and apply to any faithful edition (e.g. Swami Gambhirananda’s or Swami Madhavananda’s translations, Advaita Ashrama).

- **TU** — *Taittiriya Upanishad*. Cited: Brahman as Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity (2.1.1); *anandamaya* passage (2.5).
- **CU** — *Chandogya Upanishad*. Cited: Existence alone, one without a second (6.2.1–6.2.2), with Shankara’s commentary.

- **MU** — *Mandukya Upanishad*. Cited: three states of consciousness (*avastha-traya*), vv. 3–7 (§2.2).
- **BG** — *Bhagavad Gita*, Shankara’s commentary (Swami Gambhirananda). Cited: *loka-sangraha* and ordained duty (3.8) (§6.3).
- **VC** — *Vivekachudamani* (attributed to Shankara). English translation by Swami Madhavananda. Cited: Sat-Chit-Ananda (vv. 152, 217); ethical prerequisites (vv. 17–19); Brahman real / universe unreal (v. 20); *jiva* as Brahman (v. 216); Ishvara/Jiva superimpositions (v. 244); clay-jar analogy (v. 251); liberation without seeker/liberated (v. 574); changeless Self (v. 393); Pancha Kosha method (vv. 210, 639).
- **DDV** — *Drig-Drishya-Viveka* (attributed to Shankara or Bharati Tirtha). Cited: seer/seen discrimination (vv. 1–5) (§2.4, §3.2, §6.3).

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